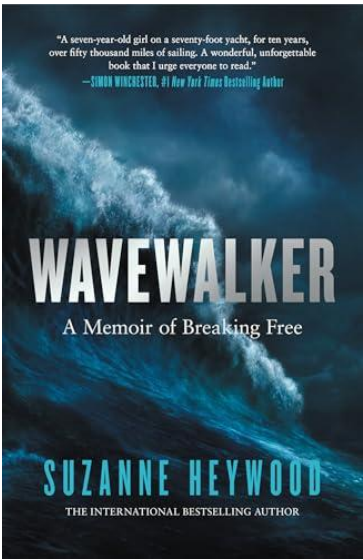




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Wavewalker: THE INTERNATIONAL BESTSELLING TRUE-STORY OF A YOUNG GIRL’S FIGHT FOR FREEDOM AND EDUCATION

by Suzanne Heywood

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Annotations (136)

- 134 Highlights | Yellow (134)
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Introduction

Page 1 | Highlight (Yellow)

the story of my childhood, during which I spent a decade sailing around the world. It takes place on a boat, which sometimes followed the route of Captain Cook’s epic third voyage, but it is more about the excitement, frustration and heartbreak of growing up in extraordinary circumstances than it is about that famous captain or his search for the North-West Passage.

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Page 1 | Highlight (Yellow)

First I needed to face my lingering fear of the ocean, which had stayed with me as an adult, so I became a qualified sailor (Yachtmaster, Offshore), the adrenalin of the experience refreshing my childhood memories.

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read my old diaries, my mother’s letters and diaries, and my father’s logbooks and papers. I also had my father’s book, Schooner to the Southern Oceans, which recounts the first year and a half of our voyage through a sailor’s eyes. Particularly intriguing (though less helpful) was a list of one-sentence memories offered by my brother Jon. These included ‘Hadn’t worn a shirt in months. Didn’t own pyjamas, shoes or socks. Lived and slept in swimming trunks. Developed boils’, and also the phrase ‘Malo e lelei efiafi’ni, malo e lelei pongi’pongi’ni, girl in Tonga’, which means ‘Good evening, good morning, girl in Tonga’ – though who the girl was, or what happened between those greetings, wasn’t explained.

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1 England: Dad’s Dream

Page 7 | Highlight (Yellow)

On the last day of school before the holidays, our teacher announced that we were going to hear the story of

Theseus, who'd gone off on a ship to fight a Minotaur in a maze. 'Why have you chosen a sailing story?' I asked, wondering if she knew our secret. 'Because it's famous,' she said. 'Do you like sailing?' 'Sometimes. When the weather is good.' I sat on the floor next to my friend Sarah to listen to the tale, which flowed out of a tape player set on a low cupboard. Theseus promised his father that if he managed to destroy the Minotaur, he would change his boat's black sails to white ones, but on the journey home he forgot to do this. When his father saw the ship returning still propelled by black canvas, he assumed Theseus had been killed and jumped off a cliff to his death. It was the first story I had ever heard without a happy ending. I held Sarah's hand while waiting for the happily ever after that never came.

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A few weeks later, we went down to the Isle of Wight to inspect Dad's find. Mum drove, as she usually did on longer journeys because my father became sleepy in cars. Their conversation was one I'd heard before – after complaining about the traffic and telling us how lucky we were that we wouldn't have to endure this at sea, Dad launched into a rant about the government's 'ridiculous tax rate', which we would also be able to escape by sailing away.

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I went up onto the aft deck to sit next to my father in the cockpit, watching him attach a compass to the binnacle, the wooden instrument stand in front of the ship's wheel. 'She's called Wavewalker,'

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'Will there be enough bunks down below for all your friends?' 'Ah.' He bit his lip. 'Actually, only four are coming with us now. Two have decided the trip will be too rough.' 'Rough?' I narrowed my eyes. Dad shrugged. 'Some of it will be. We're going to sail across more than thirty thousand miles of ocean. And we'll be going the wrong way around the world, beating into the wind.' 'Why don't we go the other way?' He checked the compass again. 'We can't do that because we're following Captain Cook. On his third voyage he went looking for a way for ships to get from the Pacific Ocean back to Europe around the top of North America. If he'd found a passage, it would have saved other boats a lot of time, and he would have won a big prize.'

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'What did the headmaster say?' 'He wasn't helpful,' said Mum. 'He wouldn't even give me your curriculum so I could teach you myself – he said he thought the whole trip was a bad idea.' She leaned out the window. 'Come on, Jon, hurry up.' She turned back to me. 'It doesn't matter. Your father and I are both trained teachers, and I'll find the materials we need.'

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'Mr Riley said that if they lose more than a year of school, they'll never recover academically,' we heard her

telling Dad. 'Well, he's a pompous ass who doesn't know what he's talking about,' said my father, and Jon and I exchanged grins. 'It's another example of what's so wrong with this country. If Sue and Jon can read and write and have a good grasp of basic mathematics, they'll be fine until they are older.' 'But has anyone put that theory to a practical test?' asked Mum. 'No, at least not to my knowledge. But I can't think of a better education than sailing around the world.'

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2 North Atlantic Ocean: Becoming Sailors

Page 19 | Highlight (Yellow)

I climbed up the ladder to the cockpit to find Dad behind the wheel, wearing his shiny yellow oilskins. 'The boat is tipped a long way over,' I said. 'Is that normal?' He laughed. 'She's heeled over, and yes, it's normal.' 'Oh. Well, can you start teaching me how to sail?' 'Not today. We have forty knots of wind up here. Let's wait until it's calmer. And you need to go back down below – it's too dangerous for you to be up here.'

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'Time to go below, Sue,' said Dad. 'The wind is getting up.' I frowned. 'Please can I stay a little longer?' 'No.' This time when I reached it, the main cabin was lurching from side to side. I retrieved Teddy from the bookcase and sat next to Jon reading my book about Rapunzel, though I couldn't get myself interested in whether she would ever escape her turret.

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'We're going to heave to,' said Dad, coming down the ladder. 'What's that?' asked Jon. 'It's like parking the boat. You do it in storms.'

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With Mum awake, we started eating proper meals, and in the calmer winds, Jon and I were allowed to sit in the cockpit in our lifejackets, watching the ocean slide past. The flying fish patrols became a regular part of our mornings and were usually followed by a fry-up of our catch. I liked the patrols but not the breakfasts because the flying fish were full of bones. But they made a change from the canned Spam and corned beef that made up most of our meals once the icebox was empty.

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'Don't do that,' I said. 'The motor might upset Henry. He just wants some company.' But my father didn't answer – instead, he handed the wheel to Owen and headed below. I kept chatting to Henry, but after a little while he dropped behind our stern, becoming a shadow again. Dad reappeared. 'Henry doesn't seem to like the echo sounder,' he told Owen. 'It seems to work as a whale deterrent.' I stared at him through narrowed eyes. Henry followed us for another day, but didn't come close again. I tried to persuade Dad to turn off the

echo sounder, but he wouldn't relent. 'Do you like Henry?' I asked Owen. 'I do,' said Owen, giving me a glimpse of his gold teeth. 'He's a lot less dangerous than that Russian tanker. But your dad's the captain and he doesn't like to upset your mum.' After two weeks of gales, whales and tankers, a pencil line appeared on the horizon. Each hour painted more details,

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We debated this issue the rest of the way ashore, and by the time we reached the dock we'd made a decision: the dinghy was Wavewalker's baby, so she would be called Ripplerunner.

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We also practised trying to get from one end of the boat to the other without touching the floor. This game was fun to play in bad weather when the cabin walls tipped over so we could walk along them, and when Mum had retreated to her bunk so she wouldn't get annoyed if we disturbed her Tupperware containers, which were arranged on shelves behind the galley. Jon always won, though it wasn't a fair competition because he was part monkey – after all, he'd already climbed to the top of our sixty-foot-high mainmast when Dad wasn't looking. 'I want to climb along the wire between the masts,' he told me one day. 'Don't be silly,' I said. 'You'll fall like Nigel did and make a mess everywhere. And don't even think of trying to do it in your sleep.'

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'Do you want to try some ship's biscuits?' asked Dad, and when I nodded he showed me where he'd hidden the tins under the step outside the main head, the name for the ship's toilet. 'Do they have raisins in them?' I asked. He shook his head. 'No, they shouldn't have.' He peered at my biscuit. 'Oh, don't worry about those: they're only weevils. Tap it sharply on the table, and most of them will fall out and crawl away. The rest will give you useful protein.'

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4 South Atlantic Ocean: The Compass

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'I am not just the Chief Islander,' he said. 'I'm also the head of the police.' 'But how do you have time to do both jobs?' I asked. 'Being a police officer here is not difficult. There's only one thief, so I know who to talk to if anything goes missing.' 'Why don't you just arrest them?' asked Jon. 'Well, if I put them in prison, I'd have to look after them. Anyway, I don't need to because I know where they live.'

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'Why does no one come here?' I asked Dad the next morning, while munching a slice of toast made with Tristan da Cunha bread. 'It's friendly, and the food is good.' 'It's so remote it only makes sense if you're sailing

from South America to Africa, and not many people do that,' he said. 'Boatharbour Bay is also unprotected, so it's often impossible to get ashore. Even the Portuguese explorer who discovered it, Mr da Cunha, never managed to land.'

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5 Tristan da Cunha to Cape Town: Being a Celebrity

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In the days after leaving Tristan, I was rarely allowed in the cockpit. When I did negotiate my way up, and stuck my head outside the canvas shelter, all I could see were grey waves rolling by, patterned by tiny hailstones. The rest of the time my world consisted of three rooms below deck – the main cabin where I read, played and ate, the chartroom where I watched Dad navigating, and the two-berth cabin where I slept.

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'Will you play Captain Blackbeard with me?' I asked. Captain Blackbeard was my favourite game – my father would pretend to be a pirate and tickle me until I begged for mercy, saying, 'Stop, Daddy, remember I'm only a little girl.'

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By then it felt like we'd been sailing forever – we'd left port so long ago that I could barely remember what Rio looked like, and I was beginning to wonder if we would ever reach Cape Town. But that changed the night I saw the Southern Cross for the first time, suspended on its side in the sky over the crested waves and beneath the Milky Way,

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When it was time to leave, I needed the bathroom. 'Be quick,' said Mum, so I ran in the direction of the signs. But when I reached the lavatories, there were multiple doors, each with a different label – African women, African men, Coloured women, Coloured men, Asian women, Asian men, Afrikaans women, Afrikaans men ... 'Go in that one, my dear,' said an elderly lady standing next to me. She pointed at one of the doors. 'Where it says, "European White".' I nodded, but I couldn't understand why they'd made it so complicated when all I wanted to do was to have a wee.

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‘You look like you need a shower,’ I told Dad when I arrived, drinks in hand, to find him covered in flakes of barnacle shell. He sat on a chunk of timber and scratched his head. ‘It’s worse than that,’ he said. ‘I can barely lift my arms and little arthropods have migrated from the barnacles into my clothes and hair.’ When the hull was clean, they applied a coat of antifouling paint, which made the back of my throat sting and Dad’s eyes look like they’d caught on fire.

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I had another question to ask Owen, since he’d seen more of the world’s oceans than anyone I knew. I hesitated, checking that no one was listening. ‘Why do we get so many storms? The people on the other schooner in the harbour here said they’d sailed all the way from America, through the South Pacific and across the Indian Ocean, without hitting any.’ Owen gazed at me. ‘Well, Sue,’ he said. ‘Your voyage is different because you are going east rather than west. That means you are sailing the wrong way – into the wind – around the world. It’s not going to be easy but completing it will be an amazing achievement. You’re lucky your dad is such a good sailor.’

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6 Indian Ocean: The Wave

Page 79 | Highlight (Yellow)

Indian Ocean: The Wave December 1976–January 1977: 7 years old Days 151 to 178 Leaving Cape Town

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Dad was right – the Indian Ocean was different. After this, nothing would be the same.

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marching forward into the distance. I’d seen large waves on our trip from Rio to Cape Town, but those twenty-foot teenagers had morphed into forty-foot giants, which made Wavewalker, and everyone on board, even Herbie, look puny. ‘I’m sorry,’ I whispered as each one rolled past. ‘I’m sorry we’re in your way.’

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After a week at sea, the wind had become a screech, a sound so eerie I was convinced that it contained the cries of sailors’ ghosts. When my father opened the hatch to come below, the howls intensified and I could see hail streaking across the slate-grey sky.

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'Is the storm getting any better?' Jon asked when Dad reached the bottom of the ladder.

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'No. It's deteriorating. I was wrong to bring us this way. This is the worst weather in the Forties for decades. Our ropes are so cold they feel like wires, and our sails are like sheets of ice.' 'Can we go back?' I asked. 'If I'd known it was going to get this bad, I would have turned back. But it's too late.'

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On Christmas morning, the boat's motion had eased a little, and when I moved my toes, I felt something resting on top of my sleeping bag. I opened my eyes to see a parcel on the end of my bunk and a bulging pillowcase on the floor. I went to get Jon from his bed in the four-berth cabin, and we made our way towards the main table, clutching our loot. The hatch opened, and Dad's face appeared, peering down at us from under his oilskins. 'I'm furious with Santa,' he said. 'Why?' we asked. 'His reindeer have pooped all over the deck, and I've been cleaning it off all morning.' Despite everything, we somehow created a little bit of Christmas cheer that day. Mum cooked turkey and roast potatoes in the swinging oven, while Jon and I opened our gifts – new books, soft toys and games.

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'How is it up there, Dad?' I asked. 'Are the waves getting any better?' He looked at me, his face expressionless. 'No. They're worse. They're now over fifty feet high. And the wind has changed direction to blow at storm force straight from the South Pole.' 'Oh.' The hairs prickled on my neck. He turned to lean over his chart. 'It's not good,' he said. He spoke the words quietly, as if to himself.

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'What's not good?' 'Having waves coming from the south and the west.' 'Why?' Another surge. We held on. Dad shook his head. 'The westerly waves break up the southerly ones. It means everything is more confused, so it's much harder to steer.' 'What can we do?' 'Very little. But don't worry, Sue. This storm can't last forever.'

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'No, he can't come down, Sue. With fifty knots of wind, your dad's the only one who can steer. The rest of us are taking turns trying to spot the waves approaching. But it's hard to see anything when it's so dark and there's water hurtling in from every direction.'

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Jon had joined me next to the table by the time Mum struggled down the ladder in her oilskins several hours later. 'Put on your lifejackets,' she said. 'We're going too fast. We must be prepared.' I didn't ask how a lifejacket would help us survive in an ocean full of gigantic, icy waves, and neither did Jon. There was little point in arguing, and anyway, Mum was already halfway back up into the cockpit. When she returned later, Jon and I were sitting trussed up in our jackets by the table.

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Mum came in carrying lifejackets. 'Put these on and stay in your bunks,' she said, her face pale in the dim cabin light. 'Do you think we're going to die?' Jon asked after she left. 'Probably,' I said, trying to put the lifejacket on without moving my head or touching the swelling above my eye. The lump seemed to be growing. It was taking me over, a foreign thing embedded in my head. 'Wavewalker is barely afloat.' 'Dad is a great captain,' said Jon. I smiled but inside my head I was imagining being back in England and no longer being part of Dad's big adventure. 'No one has answered our mayday calls,' said my brother.

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My father appeared in the doorway, water dripping down his oilskins. 'How are you?' he asked. 'We're fine,' said Jon. 'But, Daddy, are we going to die?' 'No, Jon. I've found an island – it's called Île Amsterdam. If we can get there, we can sort everything out.' My brother and I glanced at each other. The boat tipped back, and more water poured in through the hatch above Dad's head. 'Well,' said Jon, and we both looked at him. 'Well,' he said again. 'I'm not afraid to die if we're all together.' Dad stared at him, and so did I. No one said anything. After a moment, Dad nodded and reached up to wipe his face with his hand before heading back out.

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By the time I emerged through the hatch a few moments later, he was standing next to Mum, staring at Île Amsterdam. She leaned her head on his shoulder, and I saw that, like me, she was crying.

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7 Île Amsterdam: Dry but Damaged

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The Wave – the name I'd given to the watery beast that had tried to kill us – had washed away our main anchor, so he was linking our remaining pieces of chain together and attaching them to our spare anchor so it could hold Wavewalker fast.

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'Je suis Commandant Ghozi, le chef de district,' he said, shaking my father's hand. 'In your calls you said that

someone needs a doctor?’ Dad gestured towards me. ‘Yes,’ he said. ‘But if you received my calls, why didn’t you answer them?’ Commandant Ghози nodded. ‘Oui, we received them. But we never answer mayday calls because they’re almost always fake.’ ‘Why would anyone send fake emergency calls?’ ‘Some of our work here is secret, so people try to come ashore. Your family is welcome, but you mustn’t go exploring alone.’

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‘She has a broken nose, a fractured skull and there is blood trapped inside the swelling on her head,’ the commandant told my parents when Dr Senellart and I rejoined them in the waiting room. I slipped my hand inside Dad’s. ‘What if we do nothing?’ he asked. ‘The swelling is pressing down on the fracture. If we do nothing, Monsieur Capitaine, your daughter could end up with brain damage. We must cut into the wound.’ After my father nodded, Dr Senellart stretched out his hand again. This time he took me into a larger room where another man was waiting. ‘I’m Monsieur Alexis,’ the second man said. ‘You need to be brave.’ ‘My head hurts,’ I said, tears trickling down my cheeks. ‘We have no painkiller for the brain,’ said Monsieur Alexis, shaking his head. ‘Not here.’

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I woke up the next morning wondering where I was. Then I touched my head, felt the bandage, and remembered I was on Île Amsterdam.

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Later that afternoon, Commandant Ghози came for tea. ‘I’m leading the twenty-seventh French scientific mission to Île Amsterdam,’ he told us, placing his coat on the arm of his chair. ‘My thirty men are based here in La Roche Godon, where we have one store, a mess hall and a power station.’

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We have a radio station and a meteorological station – we release a weather balloon every day.’ ‘Can we see one go up?’ I asked. He looked over at me, his eyes drifting towards my bandage. ‘Of course.’ He took another sip of tea.

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‘Is Dad okay?’ I asked Mum during one of these walks since he’d looked pale when he’d last come ashore. ‘He’s still recovering,’ she said. ‘He fractured several ribs in the accident. They’re healing but are still painful.’ ‘How did he hurt his ribs?’ Mum said nothing, so I kept silent for a while to see if she would answer. I’d tried several times to get my parents to talk about the Wave, keen to unravel my memories, but they’d always refused to do so. We walked a little further before she sighed. ‘When Wavewalker tipped onto her side, he was flung overboard.’ ‘He was in the sea?’ I asked, my hands clenched into fists. ‘Yes. But his lifeline was attached to the rails, so when Wavewalker came back up, he was hauled out with her, hitting the main boom.’ I glanced at Mum, but she was looking at the path. I tried to imagine how my father had felt when he’d found himself in

the ocean. When he'd seen Wavewalker about to raise herself back up, had he worried she would leave him behind? Perhaps he'd grabbed her rails, determined to be rescued from the waves? Or maybe Wavewalker had dragged him back on board by his harness, without giving him a choice?

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At night, before I went to sleep, I wrapped my arms around Teddy and told him to keep me safe. But when I closed my eyes, I often found myself back in the four-berth cabin on Wavewalker, huddled cold and wet in my bunk. As we went down each wave, the water swirled towards me full of lost things – our toys and games from Father Christmas, waterlogged books and soggy pieces of fabric my mother would never make into a flamenco dress. These dreams came most nights, so I dreaded going to sleep and woke most mornings in a damp sweat from my night terrors.

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The first stop on Commandant Ghози's tour was the weather station, where we watched a machine pump hissing helium into a balloon. It grew to five metres in height, straining against its harness like a living thing. When the pressure became almost unbearable, a man set it free and we watched it float up into the atmosphere trailing a string. Next we visited one of the island's gardens, created at the bottom of a crater so it would be protected from the wind. The crater was the size of a tennis court, with steep, overhanging walls and its base was filled with soil the mission had shipped to the island. 'Every man has a garden,' said the commandant, 'and he uses it to produce enough vegetables to feed everyone once a month.'

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Dad and I examined the vegetable patch while Mum and Jon went to look inside the cave at the back of the crater in which the garden's owner had stored his barrels of wine.

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'When will we set sail on Wavewalker?' I asked Dad. 'Ah. Has your mum talked to you about that?' 'No.' 'Well, for once the French and English governments have agreed on something. They've decided that Wavewalker is not safe enough for Mary, you or Jon to come back on board. So I'm going to sail to Australia with just Larry and Herbie.' I clutched his hand. 'But what will we do when you've gone?' 'Don't worry. I'll find a way to get you off the island. Then we'll meet up again in Fremantle.' 'I don't like it,' I said. 'We don't have a choice, Sue,' replied Dad. His voice was raised and for the first time I noticed how nasal he sounded. When I looked up I saw that his nose was swollen and bent over to one side.

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Hanging off a hook at the back was a dead cow, its head lolling and dripping blood. 'You can take whatever you want,' said Commandant Ghози. 'We'll eat what is left or use it to bait the crayfish pots.' I avoided looking at the carcass. 'What are you going to do with it, Dad?' He raised his eyebrows. 'Carve it up. I'm pretty good at

doing that because I worked in a butcher's shop to pay my way through grammar school. I think I'll get at least a dozen fillet steaks out of it as well as a fair few sirloins, T-bones and prime ribs. Enough to get us to Australia.' 'We've also brought you some wine,' said the commandant, picking up a couple of bottles from a crate in the back of his car. 'The Burgundy will work well with the beef, and this Muscadet is excellent with crayfish. But you'll need more food than this, Capitaine. Our mission is almost over, so you can take anything you want from our stockrooms. We have plenty of Camembert, Brie, pâté, foie gras, truffles and caviar.' My father grinned. 'Thank you – we'll eat like kings.'

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'Good, but are you sure you want to sail to Australia, Capitaine? Wavewalker is still leaking so the French and British authorities have both asked you to reconsider.' 'They have no choice in the matter, Serge. The decision to sail is mine alone, and if they try to stop me, I will resist by any means I judge necessary.' I watched my father as he said this. I also wished I could change his mind, because, like the commandant, I didn't want him to go. But if he wouldn't bend for all the important people in the world, I doubted he would listen to me.

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Each afternoon Captain Cosker brought us radio reports from Wavewalker. A few days into our voyage, he said that Dad was struggling with his breathing: 'He's decided he needs to re-break his nose.' Mum sat down. 'How's he going to do that?' 'He hasn't said – but he has decided that he'll have to do it himself because no one else will,' said the captain. 'He'll drink a bottle of whisky before he does it.' We stared at him. 'I have good news, though,' Captain Cosker went on. 'It looks like we'll reach Melbourne ahead of Wavewalker's arrival in Australia. We'll fly you from there to Perth, so you'll have plenty of time to prepare a welcoming party.' Captain Cosker was right – our plane landed at Perth airport at one o'clock in the morning of my eighth birthday in late February.

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8 Fremantle to Melbourne: Little Mouse

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Fishing boats with their nets and hoists folded on their decks, sailing boats with their masts and booms empty of canvas, and motorboats with their engines and gleaming paintwork, trying to be more than pale imitations of real boats.

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small crowd had formed on the pier by the time I got back up on deck. The twins were there and so was Pippa, who was clutching Jon's plastic robot. He caught my eye and grinned, his cheeks flushed. 'Well, I didn't want it anymore, and she said she liked it.' And then we were away, turning from the jetty, pulling our ropes back in and motoring out into the bay. I stood on the stern watching the crowd get smaller until eventually it disappeared into the jumble of the boatyard behind.

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Dad's article for Reader's Digest (Gordon Cook and Alan East, 'I'm Not Afraid to Die if We're All Together', February 1978, pp. 40–45) became one of its most widely read stories after the Indian school authorities made it a set text for their English curriculum.

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9 Melbourne to Auckland: Departures and Burials

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I couldn't remember the last time I'd talked to a girl my own age. I considered walking past them to the trees beyond, but after one of them smiled at me, I found myself helping to run a make-believe hotel, becoming so engrossed that I was startled when a bell rang to call us in for lunch. 'We're leaving soon to go to a farm,' said Mum, when I joined her inside. 'But I don't want to go,' I said, picking at a sandwich. 'I'm having fun here.' I went back out to play, but the game soon dissolved and the girls ran off. When I went back in, the dining room was empty, and so was the lounge. I ran up and down the corridors looking for my parents. After a while, I stopped and sat, sobbing, against a wall. A lady in an apron, her hair drawn back, loomed up from the end of the hall. She patted my shoulder. 'Don't worry, dear,' she said. 'I'm sure they'll come back tomorrow.' 'But what if they don't?' I wanted to ask. 'What do I do then?' But I didn't because I didn't want to know the answer. That evening I had dinner at the orphanage, though I ate little.

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The next morning, my parents reappeared. 'Did you have fun?' asked Dad. 'No. I don't want to stay anywhere without you ever again,' I said. He smiled but didn't respond because he was already talking to the lady in the apron and then pulling my hand as we made our way towards the door. After climbing into the car, I looked back to see one of the girls standing at the window. Our eyes met and I felt guilty that I had parents who were taking me away. Like many things in my childhood, the night I spent in an orphanage was never discussed. However, it would be years before I risked staying away from Wavewalker again.

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Jon and I also tried snorkelling for the first time, discovering a kingdom under the water where black-and-yellow-striped angelfish ruled over zebra-striped bannerfish, and tiny, blue and orange damselfish swam in well-practised lines around coral towers. Our next stop after Moala was Vatoa Island to the south-east. 'We're back in Cook's footsteps at last,' said Dad,

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11 Samoa to the Line Islands: Chasing Cook

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we set sail again, this time heading for neighbouring American Samoa, a hundred miles away. After a night at sea, I went up on deck to find we were approaching Tutuila Island, its steep mountains covered in dense forest. 'Wow,' I said. Dad nodded. 'It's beautiful. But I need a cup of tea. Why don't you take over the wheel for a while? Keep her on ninety degrees.' I shuffled into position, gripping the spokes. Our bow moved north across the horizon, so I rotated the wheel the other way. The bow swung back, the compass spinning, and behind us our wake became a looping curve in the ocean. I learned from my over-correction and made my adjustments smaller. The compass settled, the needle swaying over eighty-five, ninety, ninety-five, before steadying with our bow pointed east. I looked up. For the first time on our voyage, my hands were the only things guiding Wavewalker. I climbed onto the seat behind the wheel to admire our progress towards the island, which was surrounded by a broad expanse of ocean reaching out to touch the sky.

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Page 161 | Highlight (Yellow)

The days merged into one another – at least they did until the morning Jon found Dad's revolver. I was sitting in my cabin talking to Barnaby when I heard the shriek and rushed out to see my brother standing in the chartroom doorway. He was pointing the gun at Mum, who was standing in the galley screaming. Dad came hurtling down the ladder from the cockpit – the only person moving in the still tableau – and snatched the gun out of Jon's hand. Mum started crying. 'It was a joke,' said Jon. 'And anyway, it's not loaded, is it?' 'How can you be sure?' said Dad. 'You could have killed your mother, you stupid, stupid boy.' She sat on the sofa, sobbing, while Jon also began to wail. 'Go to your bunk,' Dad told him, and I pressed myself back against the wall, out of the way.

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When we went ashore, we found the island children sitting under a thatched shelter receiving sweets from one of the village men who was dressed in a grubby Santa hat. 'Why do they only get candy?' Jon asked. 'Santa brings different things to children in different places,' said Dad. It was a puzzling answer, but when Jon and I discussed it later, I told him Santa must be real because otherwise Christmas would be a giant conspiracy involving every parent in the world, which seemed unlikely.

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Five days later, we sailed back into Horseshoe Bay on Fanning Island, and I ran to the bowsprit to see if I could see Jon. 'He'll be fine,' Dad had said again that morning. And he was right – when we got ashore, we found him playing with Daniel and Donald. 'But weren't you worried we wouldn't come back?' I asked. Jon shrugged. 'I was pretty sure you would.'

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12 Hawaii: Third Voyage Complete

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'We need to inspect your boat,' he said. 'No, you don't,' said Dad. 'We've already been inspected.' 'Well, we're still going to,' said the man, giving us a smile that revealed his teeth. 'Sue,' Dad said, watching the man, 'go down below and get the machine gun, the revolver and the ammunition.'

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'Get away from my boat,' shouted Dad, lifting his gun. They froze. Dad flipped the machine gun's safety catch and fired into the air. The explosion burst through my skull, my legs buckled, and I jammed my foot against the base of the cockpit cover to keep myself upright. 'If anyone puts their foot on the deck, you should shoot their kneecaps off,' Dad told me in a loud voice. I raised the revolver and pointed it at the man closest to me. The gun was heavy, and the barrel waved in the air. For a moment it seemed like nothing would happen. Then a man up near the bow let go of our rails and dived into the bay. A moment later, the others followed, diving into the water and resurfacing, kicking their legs to keep afloat. One of them started swimming back towards his dinghy, which was still tied to Wavewalker's rails. Dad rushed towards him. 'If you get any closer, I'll shoot you,' he said, lifting up the machine gun. The man paused, treading water. Then he turned and began swimming towards the shore.

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there was something in Mrs Floyd's smile that made me trust her. So I began talking, the words tumbling out while I watched the door in case Mum or Dad returned. I remembered more than I'd realised about both the accident and the days afterwards. 'After the Wave hit, did you see anything?' she asked. 'Did you see God?' The question was unexpected. 'I don't think so, but I don't know what He looks like.' Mrs Floyd nodded. 'I think God saved your life,' she said with conviction. I shivered. 'Why would He do that?' 'I don't know. But I'm sure He wants you to do something. Would you like to come to my church, the Sunset Beach Church? Maybe we can figure it out.' 'I'm not sure. Mum and Dad don't like religion.' Mrs Floyd smiled. 'Lots of kids come to Sunday school.' I returned her smile. 'Then I will if I can.' At the end of July, for the first time that I could remember, I went to church.

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mixture of beagle and Basset hound with other things probably thrown in, Albert had a tubular black and

white body on short, stumpy legs, large brown eyes and a permanently sloppy grin. 'I'm not normal,' I told him, rubbing his belly while he wagged his tail, sweeping it back and forth on the cockpit bench. 'Being normal means sleeping in a house. It means going to school and staying in the same place.' Albert turned over, scrambling to his feet to look at me. I stroked his ears, and he rested his chin on my lap. 'There are good things about living on Wavewalker,' I said, wagging my finger at him. 'My friends haven't sailed past whales, seen flying fish or swum in the ocean.' Albert yawned. 'But do you want to hear a secret?' I asked him, leaning closer. 'I don't want to be different – I want to be normal. I don't want to be stuck out at sea away from my friends. I know Mum and Dad would laugh if I told them this, but I want to be like Heidi and Sandy and go to school every day. Do you think I'm being ungrateful?'

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13 Hawaii: Languishing in the Sandwich Islands

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I took hold of his hand. 'Can we go to school?' 'Maybe. You'll need to ask your mother about that.' Asking my mother was a reasonable suggestion, but unfortunately Mum and I were barely speaking by then because she found my sadness about leaving Sandy and Heidi annoying. Stop being mardy, she kept saying, pursing her lips and looking away. And this would usually be followed by days of silence. So instead, when we got back on board, I went to find my diary.

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Page 179 | Highlight (Yellow)

'What's Dungeons and Dragons?' 'It's a game where you explore imaginary dungeons. Girls don't play it.' 'Well, I'm coming with you.' He shrugged. 'Okay.' I followed Jon off the boat to a room over the boatyard shop, where several boys were clustered around a table. When I took a seat, they looked up, but no one said anything, and soon we were busy creating characters – mine was a fighter named Aliana – and beginning an adventure. After that first afternoon, Jon and I played Dungeons and Dragons every day. Boatyard sounds drifted in through the window:

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After several weeks of this Dad announced that it was time for us to present the last of our Wedgwood plaques to George Ariyoshi, the governor of Hawaii. We all put on our best clothes for this occasion – I wore a blue cotton dress I'd found in a charity shop, Mum dug out a white suit she'd brought from England, and Dad and Jon flaunted brightly patterned Hawaiian shirts – and waited in steaming heat in the courtyard of Honolulu's town hall. 'Someone needed to mark the anniversary of Cook's voyages,' Dad told the governor when he appeared, flanked by three men in dark suits. 'So we've followed him across almost twenty-five thousand nautical miles of ocean to get here.' I stood next to my father, watching the governor incline his head as he listened to Dad talk about the difficulties we'd overcome. I remembered Mum telling me back in England that we were 'lucky' Dad wanted us to join his bicentenary voyage – and I still wanted that to be true. A photographer crouched in front of us, peering through his lens, when Dad presented the plaque to the governor. And afterwards I was given a necklace made of yellow and white frangipani flowers.

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A few days after we met the governor, Mum found a job selling timeshare apartments in a hotel by Waikiki Beach. She also started talking to me again. I'd hated her ignoring me – it made me feel sick – but I'd learned there was little I could do about it. So instead I coped by retreating inside myself while I waited for her to forgive whatever it was I'd done wrong. With her first pay cheque, Dad bought a tiny, second-hand television.

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After a while, I discovered this new gadget contained more than just cowboys and fell in love with a science programme called Cosmos. This drew my attention up to the solar system, galaxy and universe, overwhelming me with how little I knew. I'd learned some maths from Mum's worksheets, and could write, though I knew barely any grammar, couldn't spell and didn't know my times tables. Fragments of history and science, some true, some possibly not, floated around in my head. For a long time, I'd wanted to go to school because I'd wanted to make friends. Now I wanted to go because I wanted to learn.

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We spent our fourth Christmas on Wavewalker moored by Pirate Pete's yard. Santa brought me a new diary, a small red volume, heavy in my hands. I filled in my details at the front and put coloured stickers on important dates. Ever since my conversation with Mr Ray, I'd kept a journal because, in a small way, it gave me control over my life.

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From time to time, we surfaced to get bottles of Coke from the machine in the yard – Jon had discovered we could get these for free if we kicked it hard enough down low on the right-hand side – and sat drinking them on the edge of the jetty.

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So at breakfast one morning, I gave Mum my best smile and raised the possibility of school again. 'Do you think we could go?' I asked. 'If we could, it would keep us busy while you're working.' She put her toast down. 'Stop nagging, Sue. You keep asking the same question. Anyway, we've decided you're not going to go.' My face flushed. 'Why not?' 'The schools here are too rough. Did you know they have "kill haole" days during which the Hawaiian kids beat up the white kids?' I turned to Dad, but he was staring at his book and didn't look up. 'But ...' Mum got up to put her plate in the sink. 'I'm not discussing it anymore, Sue – I have to get to work.' She pulled on her jacket. 'You can write an essay about Waimea Falls Park today. I'll look at it when I get home.' 'Oh,' I said, because I didn't want to write an essay. I wrote all the time, though she didn't know that. What I wanted was knowledge – information, facts. I was drowning in unanswered questions. How did a tree form the wood that made our table? What made up the air in my lungs? Why was the sun warm while the sea was cold? After Mum left, I stayed at the table, staring at my bowl. 'I think we should start having family debates,' said Dad, looking up. 'The first one will be on abortion. Do you want to be for or against?' I blinked. 'Debates?' 'Do you want to have one?' I nodded. 'Sure. And I'll be against abortion,' I added, since I knew this

was my father's view. 'Okay. Well, you have a week to get ready.'

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My father got up to refill his drink. 'Despite the arguments, I still don't agree with abortion,' he said. 'Under any circumstances, it's murder.' Mum started washing the glasses, but I didn't move or say anything. The debate had changed my view – I no longer believed that, under any circumstances, abortion was wrong. And if Dad was mistaken on this, what else was he wrong about?

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'Ah,' he said, 'we have a draw.' He looked at Jon and me, and I sat up straight, ready to explain my choice. My father glanced at Mum and lit a fresh cigarette. 'What you kids must realise,' he said, leaning back and blowing out a mouthful of smoke, 'is this isn't a democracy. It's a benevolent dictatorship. The captain always gets the casting vote.' He picked up his glass of rum and Coke and raised it towards us. 'And I think we should go back down the Pacific.' 'But, Dad,' I said, while Mum and Jon laughed. 'It's a benevolent dictatorship, Sue,' he said again. 'I thought you knew that.'

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I delayed bringing this up for ages, fearing my mother's response because she had an ample bust and often joked about my more modest figure. But though I was petite, it was becoming embarrassing to do anything more active than walking. 'Mum, can I buy a bra?' I asked one afternoon. She guffawed. 'You're kidding, aren't you? There's nothing there.' I shook my head. 'No, I'm not kidding.' But I didn't mention it again, and in the end, Heidi's mother, Pat, solved the problem after she overheard me discussing it during one of my visits to Oahu's North Shore, buying me three at a local mall. I hugged her in the car park afterwards, unable to find the words to say thank you.

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Jon and I started going to Eric's boat to play Monopoly. And one day, walking back to Wavewalker with Jon ahead of us, Eric pulled my elbow and kissed me on the lips. It didn't feel like much, but I was thrilled – I'd feared no boy would like me because I only had one dress, I played Dungeons and Dragons, and I could fire a gun. Our romance didn't last long, however. Two weeks later, Eric flew back to California for the start of the school term. He gave me a second kiss before leaving and promised to write.

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We spent our remaining evenings in Hawaii on Larry's boat, waiting for Dad to radio through to say that he'd arrived in Tahiti. When at last he called, he was full of news. Elena, who'd gone with him to do the cooking, had turned out to be an Indian princess. She'd also been a good chef, though a little liberal on the herbs. However, one of the other crew members had brought cannabis on board, and after he'd refused to say where he'd hidden it, Dad had thrown all his bags overboard.

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14 Tahiti to Australia: Rebellion

Page 194 | Highlight (Yellow)

We were staying at the Tahara'a Inter-Continental Hotel, ten miles east of Papeete. Jon and I had christened this the 'upside-down hotel' because its reception was at ground level, while its bedrooms tumbled ten storeys down the cliffs to the black sands of Matavai Bay. It was an ingenious way, Dad said, of constructing an eleven-storey building without breaking local planning laws banning anything taller than a coconut tree.

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unlike Dad, who was oddly fascinated by the Swiss author Erich von Däniken's theory that the earth was once populated by aliens, I didn't think it was credible.

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'No, Sue. You need to help your mother down below,' said Dad. I frowned. 'Why?' 'You know the rule. Once we've put a reef in the main, you must wear a lifejacket and harness to be up on deck.' 'Okay.'

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When I heard a noise, I turned to see Jon facing me in the galley. He grinned, holding up an orange jacket. 'Were you looking for this?' 'Yes. Is there another one?' 'No. This is the only child-sized jacket and it's mine – I've been using it since we left Hawaii.' He twisted his shoulder to slip it on. 'So I guess you'll have to stay down below.'

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The second part of the voyage was grim. Far later than my friends back in Hawaii, my first period had arrived, and I lay curled up in my bunk for several days, racked with pain and unable to move. 'You'll get used to it in the end,' my mother assured me. But if the rest of my life was going to be like this, I didn't want to grow up.

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We played together all that day and most of the following one. This was rare for us because by then we lived in different worlds, with the segregation between Jon's role on board Wavewalker and mine far clearer than it had been before we'd arrived in Hawaii. I wanted to fight against these expectations, which left me trapped in the galley with my mother, but I didn't know how. Though I'd considered it, there was no point in fighting Jon for the lifejacket because by then he was far stronger than me. And appealing to my parents was unlikely to work – when my brother and I argued, my father usually refused to get involved and my mother almost always took Jon's side.

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My father smiled. 'You're getting good at identifying constellations.' I nodded, slipping my hand into his. 'And I still want to learn how to navigate. Can you teach me how to do it this trip?' He raised his eyebrows. 'Yes. If you want to.' His log entry for that night read: 'Nice night. Occasional squalls. No Great Bear. Barnaby miffed.' During the rest of our voyage to American Samoa, which included a brief stop at Penrhyn for fresh fruit, I spent whatever time I could stalking Dad. After he completed each sight, I took the sextant, peered through it and made my own measurement of the sun's position. Down below, I quizzed him on his calculations. After a while, he accepted me as his shadow, and by the time we reached Pago Pago, I'd learned how to calculate our latitude from the angle the sun formed with the horizon when it reached its zenith.

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'What are you doing?' I asked, chasing after her. She didn't answer, and I emerged into the cockpit to see her waving the tape at Dad. 'I can't stand this anymore,' she said. She leant back, extended her arm behind her head and threw the cassette into the air. It spiralled across the sea, a loop of tape playing out behind it, and splashed into the water. Dad turned his head to stare at the ripples and then looked back at us, his mouth open. Mum gave a hesitant, coughing giggle, watching him. A long moment passed before he returned her smile, and we all burst into gales of laughter.

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All this time, I was conscious of Dad's presence on the other side of the cockpit canopy. During the tack, he'd stayed behind the wheel, but as soon as it was over, he strode out onto the deck, his hair blown back by the wind. 'Don't you ever come out here again in weather like this without a lifejacket on,' he said, looming over me. I leaned backwards, still holding the mast. 'Well, I will,' I said, surprised by the control in my voice, 'whatever the weather. And I'll keep doing it until you get a second child's working lifejacket or let me share the one we already have.' We stood eye to eye, neither of us moving. I held my breath, conscious that I couldn't predict his next move. Then he muttered something inaudible and walked back to the cockpit.

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Page 202 | Highlight (Yellow)

One day shortly after Christmas, Jenner set sail south from Mooloolaba, taking Cathy away. Though I knew boat friendships were ephemeral, I still stood on the end of the jetty crying when she left.

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15 Australia: School at Last

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Each morning we rowed ourselves ashore and walked to the bus with our bags slung over our shoulders. After picking us up, the bus drove down the peninsula and along the Mooloolaba Esplanade with the shops on one side and a broad sandy beach, visible through pine and paperbark trees, on the other. Children piled in at each stop, though if big waves were rolling in, half the boys got back off when we pulled up by the surf club at Alexander Heads.

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After a few weeks, I started making friends. The turning point came one breaktime while I was standing in a long queue of kids that snaked across the playground, waiting to buy a snack from the kiosk. I'd almost reached the counter when a broad-shouldered boy elbowed in front, forcing me backwards. It was a miscalculation – I was hot, grumpy and in no mood to be pushed around – so I put my hands on his back and shoved him out of the line. The other children laughed and pointed while he glared at me and sloped off. Several turned to smile, and I grinned back.

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The other kids were not afraid of much, but even for them, Mr Hirst, our squat, red-faced deputy headmaster, was an object of terror. Jon and I had first encountered him during the monthly religious assembly. He'd stood on the balcony barking out instructions while the school lined up below in the playground: 'Catholics to A4, Lutherans to G3, Uniting Church to H5', and so on. Everyone had filed away, leaving my brother and me standing alone in the scorching sun: two small, skinny kids looking up at Mr Hirst on his shady perch. Jon put up his hand. 'Please, sir, where do atheists go?' 'They can go anywhere they want,' Mr Hirst said, turning on his heels and disappearing into his office. When we told my father this story later, he guffawed. 'He missed a brilliant opportunity,' said Dad. 'A much better answer would have been, "To hell, my boy, to hell."'

Aug 25, 2026

Note: Me too!

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After a while, I heard Dad approaching. He leaned on the doorframe and gave me a crooked smile. 'I'm sorry. I guess things got out of hand last night.' I shook my head. 'Are you going to apologise to Joanne's father? She's my best friend.' The smile went. 'No, Sue, I'm not going to apologise.'

Aug 25, 2026

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I'd started talking to my father again – after all, what else could I do – though I was unsympathetic when he found out that he'd broken his hand punching the table during his argument with Joanne's father.

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Dad took a sip of his drink. 'The problem is I need to pay Kevin before our first customers have paid us. So I'm going to need to borrow the hundred dollars you've earned babysitting.' My heart sank – I'd boasted about my savings to my father a few nights before, having gradually built them up, a dollar at a time. 'Sue, it's time for you to help the family a little.' 'But I was going to buy a swimsuit.' Dad raised his voice. 'A swimsuit? Don't you think our business is more important than a swimsuit?'

Aug 26, 2026

Page 215 | Highlight (Yellow)

When I went back up to give it to him, I also showed him my school results. 'These are good,' he said. 'They are,' said Mum, looking at them over his shoulder. She took another sip of her wine. 'But we always knew you'd be fine – your entrance tests put you two years ahead of your age group.' I looked at her. 'What? Why didn't you tell me? I've spent the whole year being bored.' 'We decided it would be better for you and Jon to be with kids nearer your age,' said Dad. 'But why didn't you ask me?' 'It was our decision – we are your parents,' Dad said, and the tone of his voice made it clear I had no choice but to turn and walk away.

Aug 26, 2026

Page 215 | Highlight (Yellow)

Dad told me he'd decided to start a landscape gardening business. 'We've already won our first job,' he said. 'We've been asked to cure a silver bark eucalyptus that is growing up through the middle of a hotel. If it dies, the hotel's owners aren't sure how they'll close the hole.' 'But what about the awnings and blinds?' 'That wasn't such a great business in the end. But this looks promising, even though I've never done much gardening before.' I took a deep breath. 'Do you think you can repay my loan?' He narrowed his eyes. 'You know I will when I can, Sue. You don't need to keep raising it.'

Aug 26, 2026

16 To the Solomon Islands Twice: Future Glimpses

Page 218 | Highlight (Yellow)

There was something else I wasn't going to tell them – my father's angry conclusion to our conversation in

which he'd said that if he could only send one child to boarding school, it would be Jon, since he'd have to look after a family one day. This had hurt, but even more fundamentally it had made me realise that my father didn't understand me at all, since I had absolutely no intention of ever waiting around at home for someone else to pay my bills.

Aug 26, 2026

Page 221 | Highlight (Yellow)

After finishing each job, I headed aft, determined to make progress, but I was usually only able to work for a few minutes before being required again. 'Can you make me a cup of tea?' Mum would ask, coming in to rest on her bunk. Or 'Can you find me my book? I'm sure I left it in the main cabin.' She would then keep issuing tasks at regular intervals: 'I have a headache – can you fetch me some water? Please find out if your father wants a beer. Can you go and see what's making that noise? Please ask your dad when we're going to tack.' At first I tried to complete all of Mum's requests, since I was wary of offending her, particularly since we were sharing a cabin. But after I realised they would never cease, I started refusing, saying I needed to work. This drew a furious response. I was being ridiculous, she said – she'd only asked me to do a few small things. Then she stopped talking to me, shuffling in and out of her bunk in silence and complaining loudly to Dad in the chartroom about my 'mardiness'. In response, I retreated inside myself, concentrating on my work and trying to shut out the world.

Sep 9, 2026

Page 221 | Highlight (Yellow)

Three days out from Brisbane, I decided I couldn't work in the aft cabin anymore. Instead I created a cave out of an unused sail in a bunk in the forward cabin and read in the milky light that filtered in through the canvas. Wavewalker's bow moved more violently than the rest of her hull as we went through the waves, which made this spot uncomfortable. But it also had a benefit – since this motion exacerbated Mum's seasickness, she was unlikely to come looking for me there.

Sep 9, 2026

Page 222 | Highlight (Yellow)

After ten days of sailing, we completed the eight-hundred-nautical mile crossing east from Australia to New Caledonia, and nosed into Nouméa harbour, tying up alongside the wharf with the usual kerfuffle of shouting, putting the engine into reverse, throwing ropes ashore and making Wavewalker fast.

Sep 9, 2026

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sat on the jetty, still shaking with a grief that felt incongruous when all around me was calm; boats bobbing next to wharves, their rigging clinking in the breeze. The horse had died in the way I feared most, claimed by the water that had once tried to claim me. My nightmare about the Wave came back again in the days after the stallion died. Now there was so much water flooding into the cabin it was flowing onto my bunk, forcing me to crane my head to reach the remaining air.

Sep 11, 2026

Page 231 | Highlight (Yellow)

What other dreams do you have?' 'Well, sometimes I dream I can fly.' I blinked at her. 'Fly?' 'Yes, I wake myself up inside a dream, and when I do, I can fly. Sometimes I even go back to England.' 'You can control what happens inside your dream?' 'Yes. But enough of this

Sep 11, 2026

17 Solomon Islands Again: Releasing the Past

Page 235 | Highlight (Yellow)

Captain Cook had gone missing. He was one of the great explorers, going further south than anyone had before. He'd mapped the east coast of Australia and been the first European to reach Hawaii and circumnavigate New Zealand. Of course, he could be criticised – a modern explorer wouldn't, for example, hand out trinkets to indigenous people. And members of Cook's crew and local people had been killed in the skirmishes that became increasingly serious over the course of his voyages. But I still didn't understand why he was being ignored.

Sep 21, 2026

Page 238 | Highlight (Yellow)

After helping clear dinner away that evening, I went back up to sit in the cockpit. Lance had left us a beautiful night, the moonlight glittering on scudding waves. Mick was on the wheel. 'Penny for your thoughts,' he said. I laughed. 'I was wondering if any of Orion's stars have planets with oceans on them. If they do, maybe they also contain girls floating on boats, surviving storms and looking out into the darkness.'

Sep 21, 2026

Page 240 | Highlight (Yellow)

Dad raised his eyebrows at this challenge to his orthodoxy. 'Didn't you see the massive churches on Ouvéa Island? Should people really be spending so much money on those?' 'I'm sure they were expensive – but they're also the centrepiece of each village, and everyone is proud of them.'

Sep 21, 2026

18 Solomon Islands to Australia: The First Hurdle

Page 255 | Highlight (Yellow)

there were magical moments. In particular I loved the minutes before dawn when the sky lightened and the stars faded while Venus lingered, waiting to herald the sun. A hesitant line of orange developed on the edge of the ocean, becoming a globe hovering above the sea, outlining the waves with gold. But these moments were exceptions to the long hours spent staring at the compass and the barely changing sea. And

Sep 21, 2026

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I took a deep breath. ‘Well, yesterday I found a pair of jeans that fit me and a T-shirt in a second-hand store. Now that some of the crew for this year have paid for their trips, would it be possible to have my babysitting money back so I can buy them?’ Dad put his screwdriver down with a clatter on top of the raft. ‘Sue, I’m fed up with you raising this. When I’m ready to pay you, I will.’ He paused before continuing, uttering his words with deliberation: ‘And let me be clear. If you ever ask me about this again, I never will.’ I stepped back. He was staring at me, and his eyes were frightening.

Sep 21, 2026

20 Australia to Fiji: No Longer Hiding

Page 272 | Highlight (Yellow)

When I got back to the cockpit, two of our eight new crew were sitting with their heads in their hands. ‘Better to sit over there,’ I said, pointing to the leeward side of the deck. Some things, like being sick into the wind, are best not learned from experience.

Sep 21, 2026

22 Fiji to New Zealand: Trials

Page 296 | Highlight (Yellow)

After William Bligh – who’d once worked for Captain Cook as sailing master on the Resolution – was set adrift from the Bounty after his crew mutinied, he became the first European to see the Yasawa Islands in Fiji.

Sep 21, 2026

Page 298 | Highlight (Yellow)

Shakespeare’s sonnets at the back of his collected works. Love is, he said, an ‘ever-fixed mark, That looks on tempests and is never shaken’.

Sep 21, 2026

Page 305 | Highlight (Yellow)

He got to his feet. ‘I’ve got to go,’ he said, leaning over to give me a brief hug. I stayed by the dockside, watching him walk up the road. Dark clouds were coming in again and this time it wouldn’t be drizzle; it would be a torrent. The world was about to cry in the way only the tropics could, and the roads, jetties and even the harbour would run with tears.

Sep 21, 2026

23 New Zealand Part 1: Forced Growth

Page 326 | Highlight (Yellow)

In early April, Jon and I went down to Tauranga to stand on a headland watching Wavewalker shrink away until she merged into the waves. Dad had again promised he would be back in a few weeks, but I had my doubts – by then I knew that the pull Jon and I exerted over our parents was weak compared to their desire to be together and my father's attraction to the sea.

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* I never visited Jon's school again, but later that year I met a man from the Milk Marketing Board who kindly let me use one of their microscopes.

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24 New Zealand Part 2: Ambition

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I watched her drink for a while. 'You're right,' I said. 'It doesn't matter why they left, does it? What matters is they're not coming back anytime soon, so I need to sort myself out.'

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'Bruce rang. He said something happened on Wavewalker, but he wouldn't tell me what it was.' She shook her head. 'If he cared about you, he wouldn't blame you for it, whatever it was.' 'Maybe my parents did something mean to his dad.' 'It doesn't matter what they did. You're not them, and he doesn't deserve you.' Simone slammed her drink down on the table, some of it slopping out. 'I told you before to stop assuming people will be kind. Only the ones who care will be kind, and there are few of those around. You have to look after yourself.'

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The next day I stopped at the garage on the way into Rotorua because there was a guy there who smiled at me whenever I bought fuel. 'I need to let my brother drive my car,' I told him, 'but how do I stop it from working if he's drunk?' 'Can't your dad stop him driving?' I shook my head. 'My dad's not here.' 'Well, in that case you'll have to be clever,' said the attendant, and he then taught me ten different ways of disabling the car, which Jon was unlikely to spot.

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I was trying not to think about my interview. I had no idea what I would do if I failed to get into Oxford and it seemed inconceivable that Somerville would accept me. I couldn't speak any foreign languages and had never

studied chemistry – two of the entrance requirements. I was sure they would see through the veneer of my knowledge to the girl underneath who'd never seen a play, heard an orchestra or visited an art gallery. There were things, of course, I did know. I could tell by the movement of a deck under my feet or the shape of a sail when something on a boat was wrong. I could see a whale, dolphin or bird and understand how it fitted into the world. I could tie a knot, chop wood, change the oil in a car, knit and sew. I knew what it was like to come close to dying. I'd lived in places where a can of tuna or a fresh onion was an unbelievable luxury. And with grim determination, I could achieve things against the odds. I hoped that some of this was what they were looking for.

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25 England Part 1: Tested

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'What are you doing here on your own?' It was a long story, but we had time. So I told her about Wavewalker, the sea, my childhood and my dream of going to university. It was odd to talk about these things so far from where it had all happened. 'But what if you don't get in?' she asked. I shrugged, trying to ignore the ball of fear inside my stomach. 'I can't go back.' 'Why not?' 'Because at last I'm free.'

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I landed at Heathrow at six in the morning. I was exhausted but wasn't complaining – after all, my return trip had been far shorter and less dangerous than my outward passage, and unlike Captain Cook, I'd made it back to England.

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27 England to Australia: Freedom

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Michael and I spent May travelling through France and Italy on trains and ferries. We stayed in youth hostels and mainly ate bread and cheese, but the journey felt idyllic, and I didn't want it to end.

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Later that evening, Max – a lanky, freckled boy from the boat next door – came over to play backgammon. 'I'm here with my father, stepmother and two small brothers,' he said, watching me move my counters, 'and I hate it.' 'Why?' 'Our boat is in the dark ages. We have nothing more advanced than a few oil lamps and an old broken radio.' He threw the dice. 'When will you go home?' I asked. 'There's no plan for us to go back. My parents spent their life savings on the boat and they think it's paradise.' He looked at me, and in his eyes I saw something that I recognised all too well – the fear of being trapped inside someone else's dream.

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‘I’m so happy you wore our skirt for your Oxford interview,’ she said, as we drove. ‘It made me feel like I was part of it.’ I started to cry, tears running down my cheeks. While I was coping with my mother, I couldn’t handle kindness from anyone else. ‘Oh, Sue,’ said Pam. ‘I hate seeing you like this – you’ve become brittle again.’ I nodded, wiping my face with the back of my hand. I was about to explain when the car juddered to a halt. I twisted the key and the engine turned but didn’t catch. ‘I think we’ll have to jump-start it,’ I said, no longer sure if I was laughing or crying. So instead of talking, Pam and I spent most of our last few minutes together pushing the car along while I leaped in occasionally to turn the key. When the engine roared back to life, we climbed back in and raced the rest of the way to the airport.

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Part Five – Aftermath

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Aftermath Cook ... emerged on the world as a master of reading, writing and arithmetic and (a little less so) of spelling. J. C. Beaglehole, *The Life of Captain James Cook*, 1974, p. 5

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28 Fiji: Looking for Wavewalker

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we decorated her beams with Fijian carvings.’ ‘Carvings?’ ‘Yes. I remember a beautiful turtle with flippers and a patterned shell. Eight people worked on her for five months.’ I asked Junior what he knew about Wavewalker’s disappearance.

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Epilogue

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Epilogue ‘But you’re so normal,’ people often say when they find out about my childhood. And in some ways, I am. But even if it’s not visible, my experience of spending a decade sailing 47,000 nautical miles on Wavewalker, equivalent to circumnavigating the globe twice, shaped who I am today.

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My parents always claimed our time on Wavewalker was ‘wonderful’ and told me I’d had a ‘privileged’ upbringing. But this oft-repeated mantra concealed a much darker story. What I found, when I mustered enough courage to look back, was that many parts of my childhood were worse than I’d been willing to admit.

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With my inability to engage in small talk, my old and faded clothes, my carvings and my pictures of dolphins and whales, it wasn't surprising I found it hard to fit

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Shortly afterwards, when I told my parents that I wasn't allowed to leave Oxford to meet my brother at Heathrow airport, they disowned me, which meant I had no way to pay for my accommodation or buy food. When Somerville became aware of my plight, they gave me tickets for meals in hall during termtime and allowed me to stay in college for my second year in a tiny room by the main staircase. Somehow I made it through my remaining time at Oxford, though I was often hungry. The easy thing to say is it worked out in the end. Indeed, by many measures, it did, through a combination of luck, grim determination and the practical skills I'd learned as a child.

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My mother's decision placed my father in her debt – she'd sacrificed everything for his dream, and in exchange, he would take her side, even when she set herself against their daughter.

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In fact, she later wrote that she'd given my father an ultimatum – 'either she goes or I do' – before they'd 'off-loaded' me in New Zealand. Even now I find those words hard to read and even harder to accept.

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Once they realised that I was telling my version of our history, they stopped visiting us and my mother threatened to damage my husband's career. None of this, however, made me stop. I had no control over my life when I was a child, but as an adult I have the right to tell my story as honestly as I can.

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However, perhaps more fundamentally, it has given me insights that I will use to guide my future: the need I have to challenge myself, to fill my world with art and music, and perhaps most importantly of all, to be with people who care about me and who will allow me to shape my own destiny.

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Page ii | Bookmark (Blue)

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